

EDUHACKERS

Eduvos Marketplace Full Research Dossier

A multi-campus student commerce, trust and entrepreneurship ecosystem



Official Hack Jam brief - source of truth for the challenge.

Research position

This dossier is deliberately broader than a normal marketplace proposal. It benchmarks the market, tests where existing campus marketplaces stop, and develops a research agenda for a verified Eduvos ecosystem spanning commerce, delivery, events, gigs, rentals, social discovery, AI compliance and Incubation Hub intelligence.

Primary audience: Eduvos students

Also for: Hack Jam judges and EduHackers build team

Team: EduHackers

Prepared by workstream: Paballo Kali - Developer / Research Lead

Version: 20 September 2026 | Scope: all Eduvos campuses | Status: desk research + research hypotheses for validation

1. Executive summary

What the evidence currently supports, what remains a hypothesis, and where EduHackers can differentiate.

The Hack Jam brief asks teams to design a digital Marketplace for Incubation Hub entrepreneurs and the wider student community, covering profiles, listings, discovery, interaction, orders or enquiries, safety, accessibility and value creation. It also judges solutions on innovation, genuine user need, practicality, scalability, accessibility and sustainability. Those criteria mean a generic listing board is not enough. [R1]

Desk research shows that many individual features the team initially considered are already present in the market. UWC has built a student marketplace with verification, search optimisation and security testing. Makethe supports verified student stores, products, services, bookings, secure payments, analytics and CRM. Campus Needs combines campus verification with protected payments and on-campus handoff. Grid has a wanted board. KANU combines entrepreneurship learning with a school marketplace and real venture outcomes. CampuzBhiz combines marketplace, food delivery, rider tracking and events. Therefore EduHackers should not claim novelty for verification, listings, messaging, requests, bookings, delivery, events or basic analytics in isolation. [R4] [R5] [R6] [R7] [R11] [R12]

The strongest white-space hypothesis is the closed loop between demand, venture creation and incubation. Instead of treating a failed search or stock-out as the end of the user journey, the proposed system tries local alternatives, other sellers, other campuses, substitute products or service slots, and finally a structured request. Repeated unmet demand becomes an opportunity signal. That signal can help an existing seller extend their offer, help an aspiring entrepreneur choose what to test, and help the Incubation Hub identify where supply or business capability is weak. Real transaction outcomes then feed back into support decisions.

Strategic thesis

EduHackers should position the concept as a verified Eduvos entrepreneurship operating system: campus-first commerce + protected transactions + demand intelligence + evidence-driven incubation. The novelty claim should be modest: this exact closed loop was not found in the reviewed public student-marketplace implementations; that does not prove global uniqueness.

The proposed concept is intentionally broad for research. Any verified Eduvos student can be a buyer and, after ID + student verification, a seller. The research scope includes products, services, food, second-hand goods, rentals, digital products, selected subscriptions, events, gigs, group orders, a campus-first short-video discovery feed, student couriers, designated pickup points, protected payments, buyer and seller trust, AI-assisted compliance, and an Incubation Hub intelligence layer. The MVP should not attempt all of these at full production depth; the research must determine which elements are essential to prove the ecosystem.

A major finding is that the proposed 2% platform commission is not the same as an all-in payment cost. Current public pricing is roughly 2.9% + R1 for Paystack local cards, 3.2% + R2 for Payfast cards, 2% for some EFT rails, and 1.5% minimum R1 for several Ozow pay-by-bank / PayShap methods. If Eduvos absorbs processor fees, a 2% commission can be negative-margin on card payments. The commercial model must therefore decide whether processing is passed through, subsidised, negotiated at enterprise rates, or incorporated into a different fee architecture. [R19] [R21] [R22]

The recommendation is to use Week 2 research to validate the biggest uncertainties rather than perfect every feature. Priority validation questions are: how Eduvos students currently discover student businesses; what makes them trust a seller; whether meaningful unmet demand exists

across campuses; whether live availability and cross-campus fallback reduce lost demand; whether buyers understand protected payment; whether entrepreneurs value demand intelligence; and whether Incubation Hub staff can act on marketplace evidence.

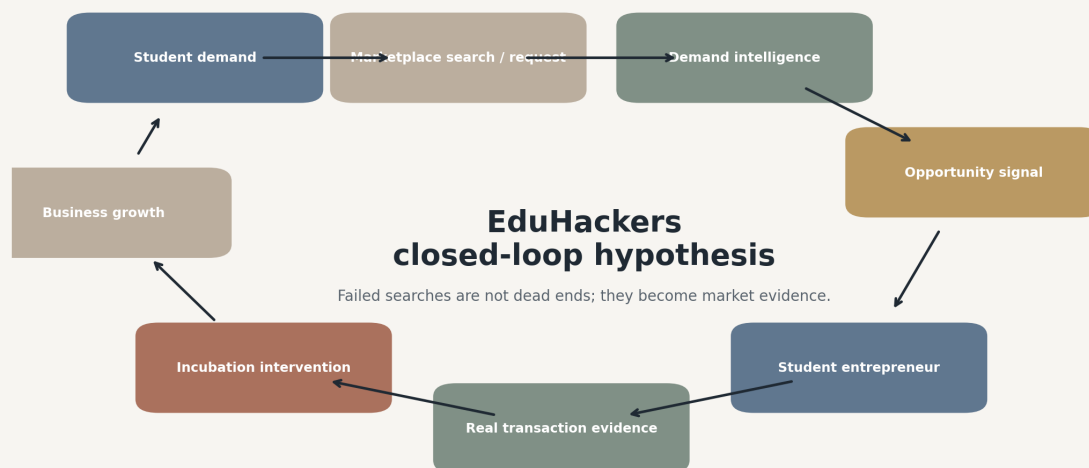


Figure 1. EduHackers differentiation hypothesis: demand becomes opportunity intelligence and evidence-driven support.

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How to read this dossier

Parts I-II establish the problem and market. Part III documents the full concept discussed by EduHackers. Part IV tests the technical, payment, legal and governance implications. Part V converts the research into interviews, metrics, MVP scope and an eight-week delivery plan. Policy ideas are labelled as proposals, not facts.

3. Method, evidence status and research discipline

This report combines four evidence types: the uploaded Hack Jam brief; public Eduvos information; current market/prior-art research; and external academic, regulatory and industry sources. A fifth layer - EduHackers product-policy modelling - captures decisions made during the team discovery discussion. These layers must not be confused.

Evidence labels used throughout

- Brief requirement: directly supported by the Eduvos Hack Jam brief.
- External evidence: supported by public academic, industry, provider or regulatory material.
- Prior art: an existing product demonstrates that a feature is already in market.
- Research hypothesis: plausible direction that still needs Eduvos user/staff evidence.
- Policy proposal: a rule the team has discussed, but which requires legal, operational or user validation before production.

The most important discipline is falsification. Interviews should not be used to make respondents agree with a pre-built solution. Instead, the team should look for evidence that its assumptions are wrong. If students already have effective discovery channels, or Incubation Hub staff cannot use marketplace data, or cross-campus fulfilment is too expensive, the product should adapt. This is stronger research than selectively collecting supportive quotes.

Research limitation

Desk research cannot establish how Eduvos students actually behave. Claims such as “students rely on WhatsApp” remain hypotheses until observed across actual Eduvos users. Findings should be segmented by campus and user type, and any Potchefstroom-heavy sample must be labelled as such.

Source quality and freshness

For current market/pricing claims, this dossier prioritises official provider pages and 2026 sources. Payment fees, app features and regulatory guidance can change; they should be re-checked before implementation. Academic studies provide context rather than direct proof of Eduvos behaviour.

4. Hack Jam brief alignment

The official challenge asks how Eduvos can create a digital Marketplace enabling Incubation Hub students to showcase, promote and sell products and services to the student community. The brief specifically calls out entrepreneur registration/profiles, listings, product/service discovery, customer-seller interaction, order/enquiry management, safety, accessibility/ease of use and ongoing value. [R1]

The brief also encourages responsible AI but requires students to remain accountable for originality, accuracy, quality and integrity; to verify AI outputs; disclose AI contribution; respect IP/privacy; and avoid uploading confidential or sensitive information. This creates a direct design requirement for the project team itself and a useful precedent for the marketplace AI layer. [R1]

Judging criteria translated into product questions

Innovative	Does the concept create a meaningful new loop, or only repackage existing marketplace features?
User-focused	Which real buyer, seller and aspiring-entrepreneur problems are evidenced at Eduvos?
Practical	Can identity, payments, disputes, moderation and campus operations work within realistic institutional constraints?
Scalable	Can the same architecture support every campus without hard-coded local assumptions?
Accessible	Can students use the platform on mobile connections, with WCAG-aligned interaction and understandable flows?
Sustainable	Does the platform retain users, create liquidity and fund/support operations over time?

The user-selected product vision broadens the original brief beyond only existing Incubation Hub entrepreneurs: the research hypothesis is that any verified Eduvos student can become a seller, with the Incubation Hub acting as a growth and evidence layer. That expansion must be presented as a proposed evolution of the challenge, not as a brief requirement.



Figure 2. Official Hack Jam 2026 brief cover - the primary project source.

5. EduHackers team and responsibility model

Paballo Kali	Developer / Research Lead	Research design, technical architecture, implementation, security, analytics, evidence traceability
Oratile Modise	UX/UI Designer	Information architecture, user flows, wireframes, Figma prototype, accessibility, usability iteration
Dikeledi Precious Phiri	Marketing Lead / Business Analyst	Requirements, business rules, value proposition, adoption research, marketplace marketing
Mpumelelo Malindi	Product Lead	Vision, prioritisation, scope, decision log and MVP cutline
Danny Mohale	Project Manager / Pitch Lead	Timeline, blockers, coordination, pitch structure, demo and evidence packaging
Sixth member	TBD	Assign after skills/role confirmation; do not invent ownership

Developer / Research Lead operating rule

Paballo's two roles create a useful advantage: research questions can become product instrumentation. Instead of doing research in a document and later guessing what to measure in code, the team can define events such as `search_zero_result`, `request_matched`, `order_completed` and `dispute_opened` before implementation. That allows the prototype to generate behavioural evidence automatically during testing.

The handoff chain should be: source → observation → insight → problem → hypothesis → requirement → Figma → GitHub issue → code → test → evidence. This keeps the final pitch traceable and prevents features from appearing without a reason.

6. Eduvos context: one institution, many campus micro-markets

Eduvos publicly operates 12 campuses. The 2025 annual report presents a national student footprint with major differences in campus size, plus an online cohort. These differences matter because a marketplace can be liquid at a large campus while remaining sparse at a smaller campus. A single institution-wide product therefore needs campus-aware discovery and a fallback to institution-wide supply. [R2]

The same annual report indicates an Incubation Hub pilot at Midrand, Tygervalley and Nelson Mandela Bay involving 22 students, which is directly relevant to the Hack Jam: the marketplace can be designed as a mechanism that helps the Hub observe and support student ventures using actual marketplace evidence rather than only periodic self-reporting. [R2]

Eduvos also demonstrates an ability to run institution-wide engagement. In 2026, its career fairs took place across all 12 campuses, with more than 1,700 students and 240 employers participating. That supports the feasibility of coordinated campus programmes, while not proving that marketplace operations would be identical everywhere. [R3]

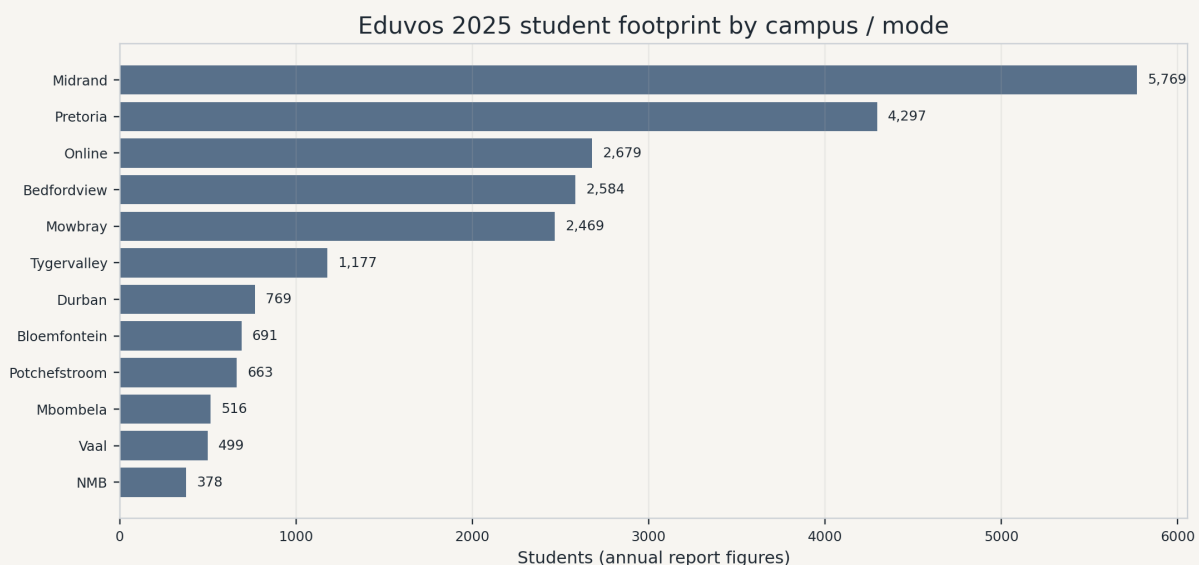


Figure 3. Student footprint from Eduvos Annual Report 2025; counts may use different institutional reporting definitions and should be treated as contextual.

Design consequence

Model Campus as a first-class entity from the beginning. Physical supply should default to the user's campus; digital services can be institution-wide; and "no local result" should trigger cross-campus alternatives rather than a dead end.

7. Studentpreneurship evidence in South Africa

South African studentpreneurship research gives useful context but should not be treated as direct Eduvos evidence. Fihla and Gavaza's 2026 qualitative work with 15 studentpreneurs found that entrepreneurship support mechanisms could be uneven, poorly integrated and inconsistently accessible, and argued for more sustained support. [R36]

Research across South African public universities has highlighted mentorship, training, networking, business advice, creative spaces, management support and funding as important support mechanisms. Another study of transitions from student to business owner identified resourcing/capability challenges and reliance on informal support networks. [R37] [R38]

Implication for the marketplace research

These findings justify testing whether a marketplace can become more than a transaction layer. If a platform can observe real demand, fulfilment, repeat customers, cancellations, seller response time and opportunity gaps, it may provide a practical evidence layer for entrepreneurship support. The key word is may: Incubation Hub interviews must determine whether those metrics are meaningful, ethical and actionable in Eduvos practice.

Questions to validate

- Do current student entrepreneurs have reliable customer-acquisition channels?
- Which support needs appear only after a student starts trading?
- Would evidence of real traction improve mentorship decisions?
- Would aspiring entrepreneurs use campus demand evidence to choose what to test?
- Where would marketplace analytics create unfair or misleading judgments?

8. South African e-commerce context: digital buying is normal, trust still matters

South African online retail is forecast at about R159 billion in 2026, up an estimated 22.5% from roughly R130 billion in 2025, and expected to average 10% of national retail turnover for the first full year. This demonstrates a mature digital-commerce context rather than a fringe behaviour. [R17] [R18]

However, internet access and online shopping are not the same. World Wide Worx reports internet access at 79.1% of adults while only 34.2% shop online, with 25-34-year-olds the highest age-group penetration at 39.5%. The implication is that having connected students does not guarantee transaction adoption; trust, payment friction, fulfilment and value still matter. [R17]

The 2026 report also describes South African shopping as smartphone-first while browser purchasing remains important across many categories. That supports the user's decision to research both a mobile app and a full web app/PWA rather than assuming app-only behaviour. [R18]

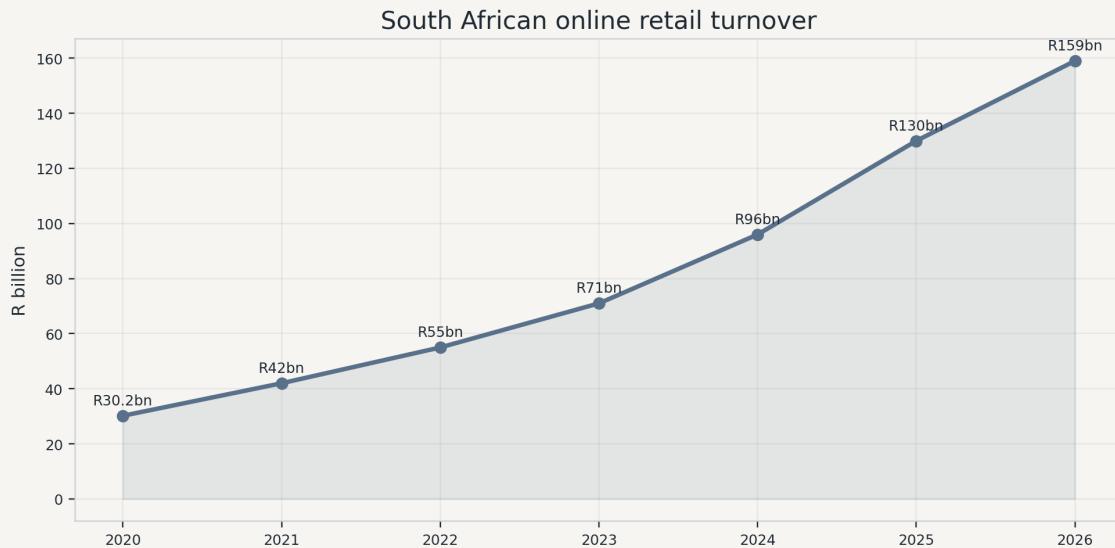


Figure 4. South African online retail turnover trajectory from public World Wide Worx / partner reporting.

Product implication

The winning interaction model is likely “mobile-first, not mobile-only”: fast browser access for discovery and checkout, a mobile app for deeper engagement/notifications, and an installable PWA/desktop experience for sellers, staff and power users.

9. South African payment behaviour and checkout design

Card remains important, but pay-by-bank, instant EFT, PayShap and digital wallets are increasingly relevant. Peach Payments’ 2026 reporting says digital wallets grew more than 35% year-on-year, 40.8% of surveyed retailers were already on Instant EFT or PayShap, and Capitec Pay represented around 40% of payment value at some processors. [R18]

The research implication is not “add every payment logo.” It is to make checkout recognise familiar student payment methods, recover cleanly from network failures, show fees before commitment, and use a payment orchestration architecture that can change providers without rewriting the marketplace. Crypto can remain a research/future rail, but it introduces reporting, volatility and compliance complexity that should not distract from the MVP.

Payment methods to compare in user research

- Debit / credit cards and mobile wallets where supported.
- Pay-by-bank / instant EFT / PayShap-style rails.
- Standard EFT only where reconciliation can be made reliable.
- Crypto as a future/high-complexity option, not a default MVP dependency.

Conversion risk

Payment choice should be evidence-driven. The 2026 online-retail report identifies card declines and shipping fees among major abandonment causes. The marketplace should instrument checkout failures and recovery, not treat every abandoned cart as lack of interest.

10. Market landscape: what already exists

The benchmark set spans campus marketplaces, student-business platforms, entrepreneurship systems and broader South African trust/payment references. The purpose is not to find one exact competitor; it is to understand which building blocks are already proven and where the combination may be underdeveloped.

Campus / student marketplace prior art

UWC Campus Marketplace shows student verification, products/services, strong search optimisation and cybersecurity testing. Makethe shows student stores, products, services, bookings, secure payments, analytics and CRM. Campus Needs shows verified campus users, protected payments and on-campus handoffs. Campus Marketplace on iOS shows verified students, Paystack, chat, search, filters and favourites. UniBay is a South African student marketplace with listings/chat and study-note functions. Student Hub Marketing supports campus listings, real-time chat and campus-focused authentication. [R4] [R5] [R6] [R8] [R9] [R10]

Grid is especially relevant because its Wanted Board lets buyers post what they need and sellers respond. This means the “buyer request” pattern is prior art. CampuzBhiz is especially relevant because it combines campus marketplace, food delivery, live rider tracking, vendor tools and event tickets. That means campus delivery + events are also not sufficient differentiation. [R11] [R12]

KANU is the closest entrepreneurship-system analogue: its current public site describes school marketplaces, AI guidance, venture activity and verified real-world outcomes. It demonstrates that “marketplace + entrepreneurship education/support” cannot be claimed as globally new. [R7]

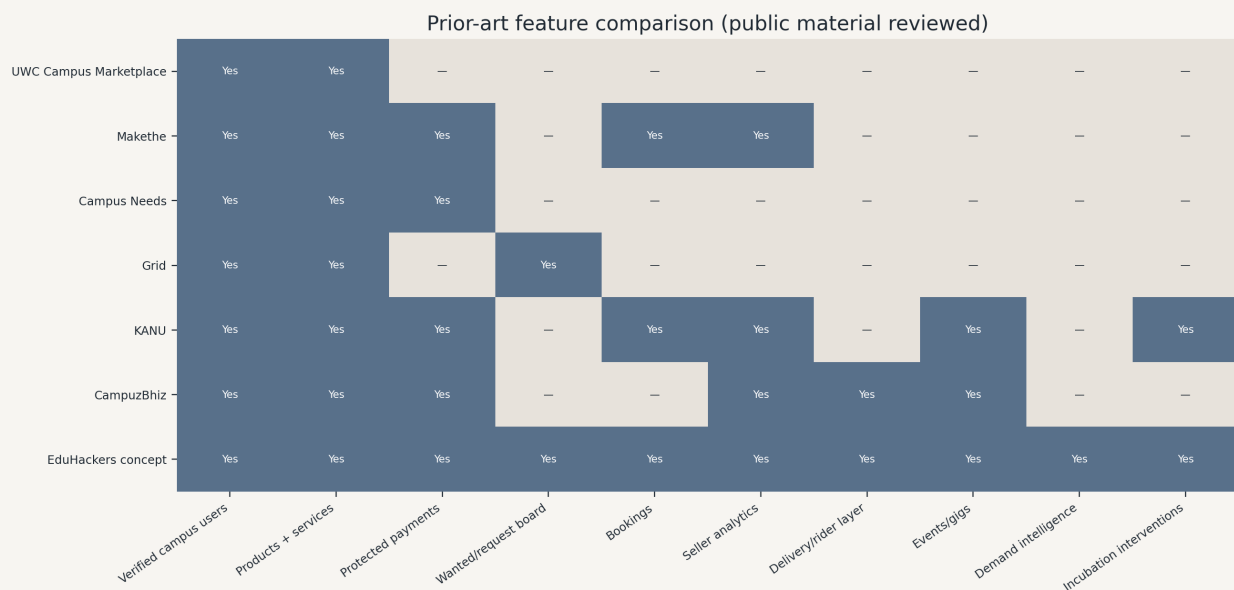


Figure 5. Feature heatmap based on public materials reviewed; blank cells mean “not found in reviewed public material”, not proof of absence.

11. Prior-art deep dive I: campus verification, discovery and protected trade

UWC Campus Marketplace

UWC's public story is useful because it documents an internal evolution from very low traffic to heavy emphasis on search optimisation. Security was treated as a first-class problem: the founders worked with campus cybersecurity groups and required student verification. The lesson for EduHackers is that discovery quality and trust are core infrastructure, not polish. [R4]

Campus Needs

Campus Needs frames its proposition around verified students, campus-local exchange and protected payments. It also emphasises on-campus handoffs. The lesson is that "verified students + safe exchange" is already a clear competitive proposition. EduHackers needs a deeper institutional loop rather than only safer classifieds. [R6]

Yaga and Bob Shop as South African trust references

Yaga's payment-protection flow closely resembles the user-selected "buyer confirms before seller payout" idea: payment is held, the seller fulfils, the buyer confirms receipt, and funds are released. Yaga also ties protection to staying on-platform. Bob Shop shows another pattern: protection levels can vary by seller verification/tier, and both buyers and sellers accumulate transaction reputation. These examples support protected payments and earned trust, while also showing that the policies require evidence, exclusions and support operations. [R13] [R14] [R15]

Proposed seller progression - trust is earned, not purchased



Figure 6. Proposed EduHackers seller progression inspired by verified/trusted marketplace patterns, but tailored to student entrepreneurship.

12. Prior-art deep dive II: entrepreneurship, delivery and campus operating systems

Makethe

Makethe demonstrates that a student marketplace can already package student verification, branded storefronts, products/services, bookings, payments, analytics, CRM and notifications. That raises the baseline. A seller dashboard is useful, but not enough to differentiate EduHackers. [R5]

KANU

KANU demonstrates a different direction: entrepreneurship education, a school marketplace, venture activity and verified outcomes. Its public site says 4,000+ student ventures and \$200K+ verified student revenue. EduHackers should therefore avoid claiming that merely connecting entrepreneurship education to a marketplace is unique. [R7]

CampuzBhiz

CampuzBhiz shows a broad campus “super-app” pattern: buying/selling, food and product delivery, real-time rider tracking, services, messaging, vendor tools and events. It is a strong warning against positioning breadth itself as innovation. Breadth can improve utility; differentiation must come from the system logic and institutional integration. [R12]

Benchmark conclusion

The feature race is already crowded. EduHackers should win on orchestration: verification → discovery → protected transaction → evidence → demand intelligence → seller development → Incubation Hub action.

13. What is not unique - and therefore should not lead the pitch

Verified university users	Already present in multiple campus marketplaces.
Products + services	Common baseline.
In-app chat	Common baseline.
Search and filters	Common baseline.
Secure payments	Common baseline.
Bookings	Already present in student-marketplace prior art.
Wanted board / requests	Grid demonstrates the pattern.
Campus delivery / riders	CampuzBhiz demonstrates the pattern.
Events / tickets	Present in broader campus app patterns.
Seller analytics	Present in Makethe and other commerce systems.
Entrepreneurship support	KANU demonstrates an integrated education/venture model.
Ratings / trusted sellers	Mature marketplace baseline.

These features are still valuable. The strategic mistake would be to present them as proof of innovation. Instead, the pitch can say that EduHackers learned from existing products and deliberately moved the innovation layer upward - from individual features to a feedback system that helps Edivos create and grow student ventures.

Defensible novelty wording

“In the public student-marketplace implementations reviewed, we did not find this exact closed loop combining marketplace telemetry, unmet-demand creation, venture validation and Incubation Hub intervention. This is a white-space hypothesis, not a claim that nobody globally has ever built it.”

14. Differentiation thesis: the Eduvos Opportunity Engine

The proposed Opportunity Engine begins with a practical user-experience rule: never end a legitimate buying journey at “no stock” or “not available.” The platform should first protect the buyer’s intent: find another seller, another slot, another campus, a similar option, or let the buyer publish a structured request. Only after those fallbacks fail does the system treat the interaction as unmet demand.

Unmet demand is then aggregated by campus, category, time and intent. A single failed search is noise; repeated patterns become a signal. The system can surface that signal to existing sellers (“students repeatedly ask for X”), to aspiring entrepreneurs (“this campus has demand and little supply”), and to the Incubation Hub (“this category has demand but low fulfilment”). The marketplace thereby becomes a market-sensing instrument.

The strongest version of the idea closes the loop by measuring what happens next. If a student launches a new offer, the platform can see listing views, contacts, bookings, completion, repeat customers and disputes. That evidence can improve business support. This is materially different from an incubator asking only whether a student “made progress.”

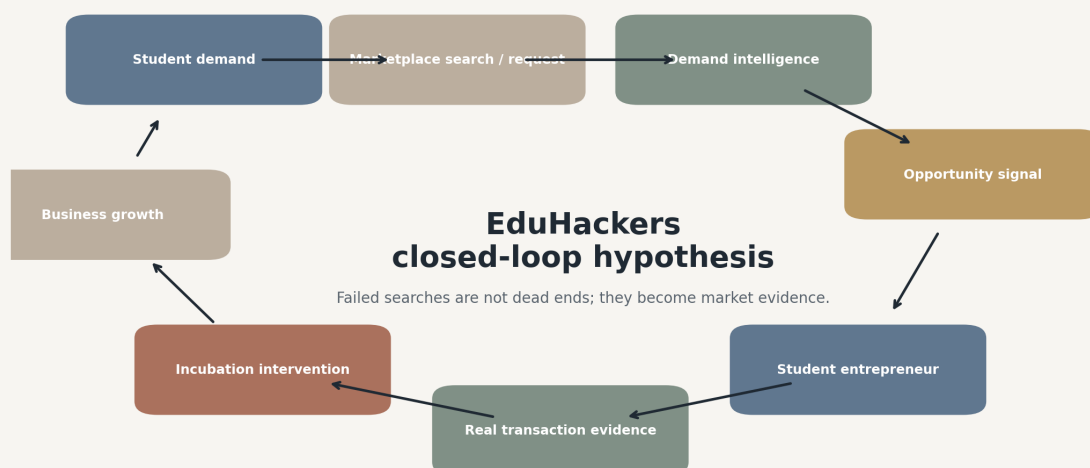


Figure 7. The Opportunity Engine closes the loop from demand to business growth.

Research questions

- Are zero-result searches frequent enough to be useful?
- Do students understand and trust a wanted/request flow?
- Can opportunity signals be aggregated without exposing individual search behaviour?
- Would aspiring entrepreneurs act on demand evidence?
- Can the Incubation Hub turn the signals into concrete support?

15. User and actor model

The concept needs more than “buyer” and “seller.” It includes transaction participants, campus logistics actors, institutional staff and moderation. Roles should be explicit because permissions, data visibility and risk differ.

Verified Student / Buyer	Discover, buy, book, rent, RSVP, review, post requests/reels	No seller credibility inherited from buyer trust
Personal Seller	Sell under verified personal profile; fulfil orders/services	Identity verified; business brand unlock not immediate
Trusted Seller	Earned benefits, storefront, selected subscriptions, larger opportunities	Must remain in good standing
Student Courier	Accept eligible delivery tasks	Location and handoff data tightly scoped
Approved Courier	Higher-trust courier status after extra onboarding	Institution-defined checks
Event Organiser	Create approved events, capacity, tickets, vendor applications	Only approved organisers
Incubation Staff	See internal business-health evidence; approve interventions	No public exposure of internal scores
Moderator	Review reports, disputes, policy violations and appeals	Human review with audit trail
Admin	Platform configuration and access management	Least privilege; not universal data access by default
AI Compliance Assistant	Flag/hold content, summarise risk, recommend interventions	No final high-impact penalty without review path

The user-selected policy is that every verified Eduvos student can be a buyer. Selling requires Eduvos student verification plus government-ID verification. Real identity stays private to the platform/Eduvos; public identity can later become a brand storefront after the seller earns trust.

16. Marketplace modes in scope

The research scope is deliberately multi-modal because student economic activity does not fit one transaction type. Products, services, food, rentals, second-hand goods, digital products, events and gigs each have different data, fulfilment and dispute requirements. Forcing all of them into one “listing” flow creates fragile design.

Shared listing core

Every listing can share seller, campus, title, description, media, category, price/pricing model, availability, visibility, trust context, moderation status and timestamps. Subtypes then add domain-specific requirements.

Subtype examples

- Product: stock, condition, pickup/delivery options, variants.
- Service: duration, availability slots, brief, booking, 30% deposit, milestones.
- Food: ingredients/allergens, preparation window, storage and compliance declarations.
- Rental: availability period, deposit, condition evidence, return deadline, late charges.
- Digital: file/version/licence, controlled delivery, download evidence.
- Event: capacity, tickets, waitlist, vendor applications, reminders.
- Gig/opportunity: brief, deadline, budget, application/quote process and approval rules.

Marketplace modes in scope for research



Figure 8. Marketplace modes being researched. Inclusion in the diagram does not mean every mode belongs in the first MVP.

17. Campus-first discovery and live availability

The user's strongest experience requirement is continuity: if one seller is unavailable, the platform should keep working rather than tell the buyer to leave. This is a direct response to marketplace liquidity problems: a marketplace fails when demand arrives but cannot find usable supply.

For products, "availability" should mean real stock plus pickup/delivery readiness. For services it should mean bookable time. The interface can show states such as Available now, Available today, Available after 15:00, Pickup today and Next available slot. These states should be backed by seller configuration or inventory rather than decorative badges.

The campus-first ranking principle is: own campus first for physical convenience; wider Eduvos only when needed. Digital services can be institution-wide by default. This reduces irrelevant results while preserving the all-campus network effect.

"Never lose the client" discovery fallback

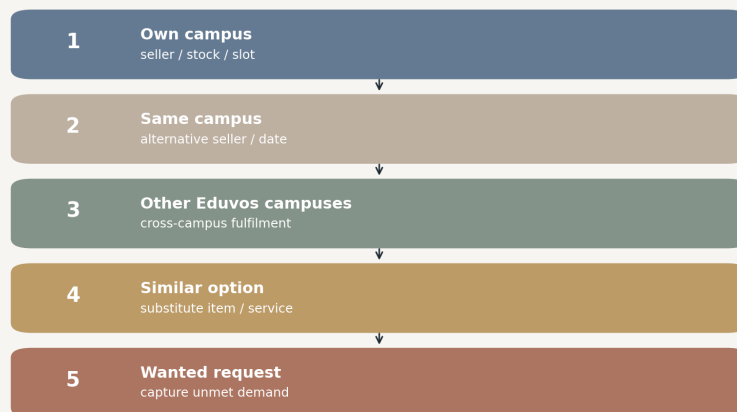


Figure 9. Discovery fallback designed to preserve purchase intent and generate structured unmet-demand evidence.

Metric consequence

Track the entire fallback chain: local search success, fallback success, cross-campus conversion, substitute acceptance and request creation. A “zero-result rate” without fallback data would understate how much demand the platform actually salvages.

18. Cross-campus fulfilment and designated pickup points

When a product exists at another campus, the research concept allows three fulfilment paths: a verified student courier transports it between campuses; the seller ships/transfers it to the buyer’s campus; or the buyer arranges collection at the other campus. The marketplace should compare these options by cost, expected time and eligibility.

For same-campus transactions, designated pickup points can reduce ambiguous meetups. The research should compare official safe zones, staffed desks, smart lockers and seller/courier handoff areas. Eduvos should approve physical locations and operating rules; the app should not infer or publish sensitive campus safety details without institutional approval.

The student-courier concept is hybrid: verified students may apply to deliver, while Eduvos or the Incubation Hub can create a higher-trust “approved courier” tier. The research must test safety, insurance/liability, earnings, late delivery, lost items, food handling and what proof constitutes a completed handoff.

Proof-of-handoff options to test

- Buyer one-time code / QR at designated pickup.
- Seller/courier and buyer timestamps.
- Photo evidence only when privacy-safe and necessary.
- Event logs tied to the order rather than exposing continuous location history.

19. Protected payments: the experience is easy; the money movement is not

The user-selected experience is similar to Yaga: the buyer pays inside the marketplace; funds remain protected; the seller fulfils; the buyer manually confirms receipt/completion; only then does the seller receive the payout. Yaga demonstrates that this buyer-confirmation pattern exists in South Africa, but its legal and payment-provider structure should not simply be copied. [R13]

The implementation should avoid Eduvos casually “holding client money” in its own bank account. PASA states that organisations accepting payments from multiple parties for a client or disbursing payments to multiple parties may need Third Party Payment Provider registration through a sponsoring bank. The architecture should therefore use a regulated payment partner/subaccount/split model and obtain legal/payment advice before launch. [R20] [R23]

Proposed transaction states

Requested → Accepted → Awaiting payment → Protected payment confirmed → Preparing / In progress → Ready / Delivered → Buyer confirms → Completed / Payout. Alternative end states include Cancelled, Refunded, Partially refunded and Disputed.

Services

The user-selected research policy is a fixed 30% upfront deposit for services, with the remaining 70% protected until completion. If the buyer cancels after work starts, a moderator decides whether the seller retains all, some or none of the deposit based on the agreed brief, timestamps, submitted work and communications. This should be tested for fairness across very different service types.

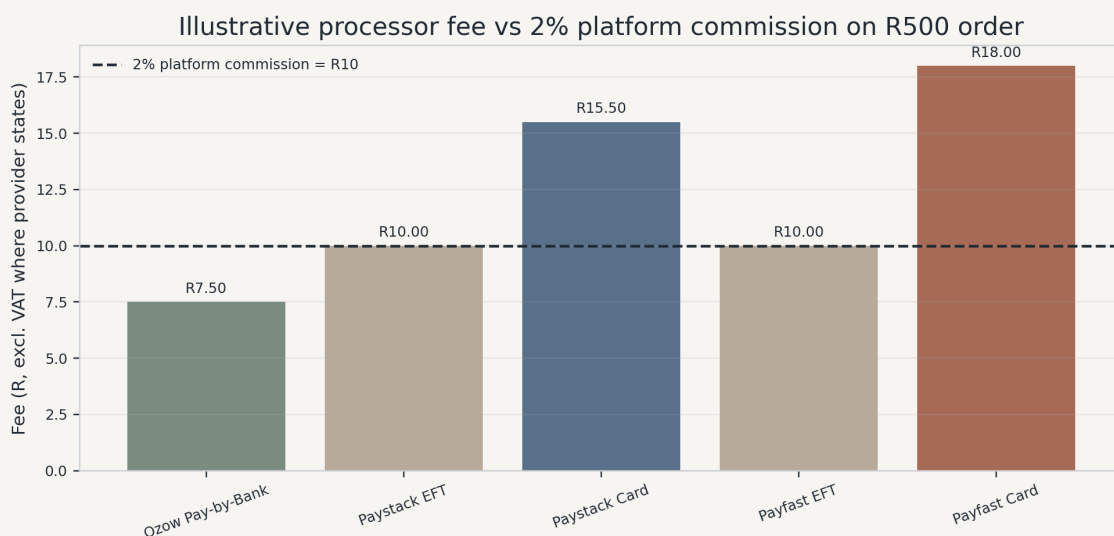


Figure 10. Illustrative processor fees on a R500 order compared with a 2% platform commission; public standard pricing, not negotiated enterprise rates.

20. The 2% commission problem: unit economics must be explicit

The planned 2% app commission is attractive to students, but processor pricing creates a structural question. At public standard rates, a R500 Paystack card payment is about R15.50 before VAT, while a 2% platform commission is only R10. Payfast card pricing is higher. Some pay-by-bank rails can fit below 2%, but not every payment method will. [R19] [R21] [R22]

This means “2% commission” cannot silently mean “Eduvos pays every payment cost and still earns 2%.” The team needs an explicit fee model. Options include: 2% platform commission plus processor fee shown separately; processor fee borne by seller; a small buyer protection/processing fee; negotiated enterprise PSP rates; Eduvos subsidy during the pilot; or a different commission after evidence. The report recommends keeping 2% as the platform commission hypothesis while validating payment-cost treatment.

This is also why lower-cost pay-by-bank and PayShap-style methods deserve prominent checkout placement, provided students trust and use them. The objective is not to push users to a payment method purely because it is cheaper; it is to balance conversion, familiarity, refunds, protection and cost.

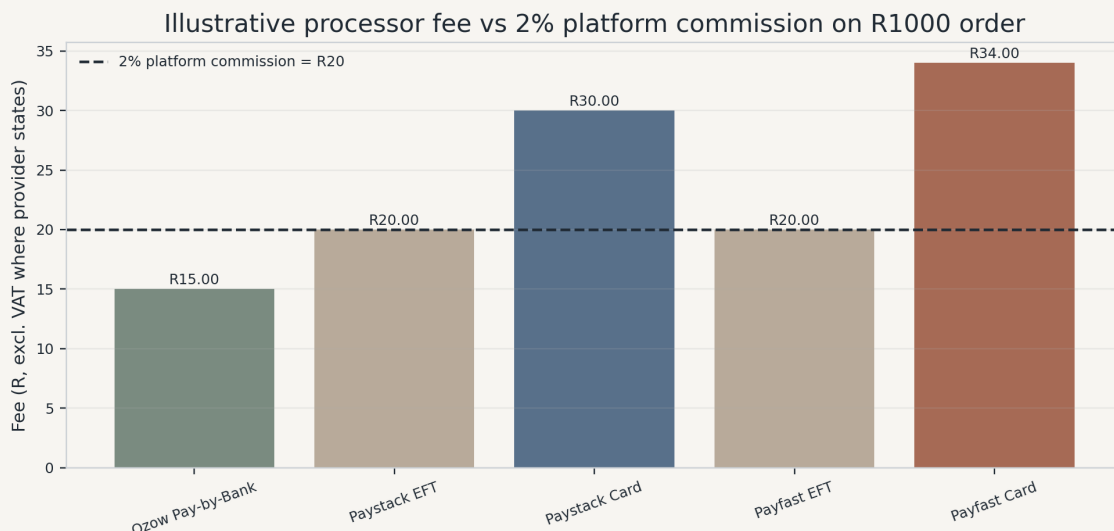


Figure 11. The fee gap remains visible at R1,000. Enterprise pricing may differ; this is a research warning, not a final business model.

Recommendation for the pitch

Do not promise that 2% covers payment processing. Say: “We propose a 2% marketplace commission and will validate the processor-fee model with Eduvos and a regulated PSP.”

21. Buyer protection, refunds, returns and disputes

The platform’s trust proposition depends on clear failure handling. Mature marketplaces such as Yaga and Bob Shop tie protection to transactions completed on-platform and define evidence, exclusions and support processes. EduHackers should do the same. [R13] [R14]

Buyer-protection cases to support

- Non-delivery / seller never fulfils.
- Item or service materially differs from agreed listing/brief.
- Unsafe, prohibited or fraudulent transaction.
- Partial failure where only part of the order/service was delivered correctly.
- Returnable physical item with evidence and policy eligibility.

Human moderation

Disputes should be reviewed by a human moderator using order data, in-app messages, uploaded evidence, delivery/handoff records, timestamps and the original listing/brief. AI can summarise evidence, detect inconsistencies and prioritise risk, but the user has explicitly chosen human review for dispute decisions.

Two-sided fairness

Buyer protection cannot become an easy refund-abuse mechanism. Buyer reputation should therefore include payment reliability, cancellations, abusive dispute patterns and failed collections. Seller reputation should separately reflect fulfilment, response time, complaints, repeat customers and cancellations. Neither side's score should be a single opaque AI number.

22. Trust architecture: verification, reputation and progression

The proposed trust model has several layers rather than one five-star score. Identity trust comes from Eduvos student verification plus government ID for sellers. Transaction trust comes from completed orders, fulfilment, response time, cancellations, disputes and verified reviews. Business maturity comes from sustained good standing and seller progression.

The user-selected storefront unlock is 10 successful sales + a recommended R1,000 cumulative completed sales value + good rating/trust standing + no serious unresolved disputes or active probation. R1,000 is a product-policy recommendation, not a regulatory standard. It is low enough to avoid excluding low-ticket businesses while still requiring real marketplace activity.

SARS confirms that a sole proprietor can trade under a fictitious/trade name without creating a separate legal entity. That supports allowing informal student brands without mandatory CIPC registration, while formal registration can remain an optional future status. [R29]

The 2026 turnover-tax threshold for qualifying micro businesses increased to R2.3 million with a R600,000 tax-free threshold, but the marketplace should not act as a tax adviser. It can provide links/education when sellers approach formalisation milestones. [R30]

Proposed seller progression - trust is earned, not purchased



Figure 12. Proposed progression. Thresholds should be piloted and adjusted from actual marketplace behaviour.

23. Trusted Seller benefits - earned visibility, not paid boosting

The user rejected paid listing boosts. This is important because paid visibility could advantage students who already have more capital. The proposed model gives stronger discovery privileges to sellers who earn trust, while reserving exposure for new sellers so the marketplace does not become permanently incumbent-dominated.

Benefits to research for Trusted Sellers

- Priority placement where relevance and availability are otherwise comparable.
- Eligibility for higher-value gigs / opportunities.
- Higher transaction or rental limits.
- Faster payout eligibility where the payment provider supports it and risk remains acceptable.
- Advanced analytics and business tools.
- Eligibility for selected subscriptions/recurring services.
- Priority eligibility for campus event/vendor opportunities.

Ranking fairness

Search should not simply sort by lifetime sales. A more defensible ranking model combines relevance, campus, live availability, fulfilment quality, trust and controlled exploration for new sellers. The weighting should be explainable and monitored for campus/category concentration.

24. Food marketplace research: convenience creates higher safety obligations

Food can be a high-frequency student category, but it is not “just another listing.” The user wants food allowed only where sellers list ingredients and understand food hazards. South African hygiene regulations and labelling requirements create a strong case for category-specific onboarding, ingredient/allergen disclosure, preparation/storage rules and institutional approval. [R27] [R28]

Proposed food controls to research with Eduvos/legal/health

- Mandatory ingredients and common-allergen fields before publishing.
- Preparation date/time and safe storage/serving guidance where relevant.
- Seller declaration that preparation location and practices meet applicable requirements.
- Higher-risk food categories routed for stronger review.
- Clear cancellation/refund rules for perishable orders.
- Delivery handoff times tracked for food orders without creating unnecessary location history.

AI role

AI can detect missing allergen fields, inconsistent ingredient claims or obviously disallowed listings, but it cannot certify that a kitchen is hygienic. Compliance AI should therefore function as a pre-publication checker and moderator assistant, not as a substitute for institutional and legal requirements.

25. Prohibited items, AI moderation and graduated enforcement

The platform needs a clear prohibited-items policy covering illegal goods, age-restricted or institutionally inappropriate products, unsafe services, explicit/adult material, academic-misconduct services and other categories Eduvos decides not to permit. The product should prevent publication where rules are clear, rather than relying only on reports after harm occurs.

User-selected enforcement flow

AI/policy check → flag → notify seller → block/hide listing → moderator review → warning/probation/temporary suspension → permanent removal for serious or repeated violations. Buyers can face the same graduated enforcement for abuse, fraud, repeated no-shows or bad-faith disputes.

Automated moderation makes mistakes. Low-confidence cases should be hidden pending review rather than trigger a punitive account action. Every enforcement action should have a reason code, evidence, timestamp, reviewer, appeal path and audit log. This is consistent with responsible-AI principles that emphasise transparency, human oversight and risk management. [R31] [R32]

Policy design principle

The safest model separates content state from account punishment. AI can block a specific listing quickly to reduce risk; higher-impact penalties should use human review or an appealable process.

26. Services: booking, 30% deposits and academic-integrity boundaries

Services need different workflows from products. Live availability, booking slots, briefs, deposits and completion evidence are central. The proposed default deposit is 30% for all services. The team should test whether users understand what the deposit covers and whether the same rule feels fair for tutoring, photography, design, coding assistance, repairs and event work.

Academic services should be permitted only where they support learning: tutoring, study coaching, proofreading, concept explanation, coding guidance and design feedback. Services that complete graded assessments, impersonate a student or enable cheating should be prohibited.

Higher-education academic-integrity guidance makes this distinction important, particularly where AI-generated work is involved. [R39]

Service evidence trail

- Original listing and agreed brief/version.
- Scheduled appointment or milestones.
- In-app messages and agreed changes.
- Files/submissions delivered through or logged by the platform where appropriate.
- Buyer acceptance or dispute with evidence.

For large service jobs, the research can compare a single 30/70 split with multi-stage milestones, but the user-selected baseline remains 30% upfront and 70% protected until completion.

27. Rentals and high-value items

Rentals extend marketplace value beyond ownership: textbooks, calculators, cameras, formal wear, gaming equipment, tools and event gear can be temporarily shared. This introduces a different risk model centred on deposits, return deadlines, condition evidence and damage/loss disputes.

Proposed rental flow

Rental request → availability confirmed → rental fee + refundable security deposit protected → condition evidence captured → item collected → return due time tracked → automatic late charges if overdue → return evidence → deposit released or dispute opened.

High-value rentals should have stronger requirements: additional identity/trust checks, higher deposits, before/after photo or video evidence, stricter renter standing and possibly category-specific transaction limits. Late fees should be disclosed before checkout and capped/reviewable to avoid disproportionate penalties.

Research questions

- What deposit level feels fair by item value and category?
- What evidence is practical at pickup/return?
- How should normal wear differ from damage?
- When should the platform require a designated pickup point?
- How should courier damage be separated from renter liability?

28. Second-hand goods and digital products

Second-hand goods

Condition should be standardised rather than free-form: New, Like New, Good and Fair, with mandatory defect disclosure and current photos. Electronics may require serial/model fields, functionality checks and stronger evidence. The user does not want swaps/trade-ins; this keeps the transaction model simpler.

Digital products

Digital products can include student-created templates, design assets, beats, presets, e-books, coding tools and study resources, subject to copyright and academic-integrity rules. Files should be versioned, scanned and licensed clearly. A buyer can receive access immediately after payment while seller payout remains protected until confirmation.

Digital buyer protection creates a special abuse risk: a buyer could download a file and then claim it did not work. The system should therefore retain download/access logs, file hashes/version history and the original listing claims. Refund decisions should be evidence-based, not automatic.

Copyright and academic integrity

The marketplace should require sellers to confirm that they own or are authorised to distribute digital content. Study resources that reproduce protected textbooks, leaked assessments or answer graded work should be blocked. The platform can permit original notes or learning resources subject to Eduvos academic-integrity policy.

29. Limited recurring services and subscriptions

The user wants subscriptions only for a limited set of appropriate categories and only for Trusted Sellers. This is a sensible restriction because recurring billing increases harm if the service deteriorates or cancellation is unclear.

Candidate categories to research

- Recurring tutoring or study coaching.
- Selected ongoing creative/technical support where deliverables are clearly defined.
- Meal-plan or recurring physical supply only if food safety and fulfilment can be reliably governed.
- Other categories only after evidence and policy approval.

Controls

- Explicit billing period and renewal date.
- Simple cancellation and future-charge stop.
- Clear missed-session / missed-delivery rules.
- No long lock-in periods for students by default.
- Only Trusted Sellers in good standing.

The MVP should probably defer recurring billing until the one-off transaction, dispute and payout model has been validated.

30. Events, gigs and opportunity marketplace

The user wants campus events integrated into the ecosystem. Students should be able to discover events, RSVP, buy tickets, join waitlists and receive reminders. Sellers can apply for stalls or vendor slots. Approved organisers can manage capacity, tickets and vendor applications. This creates a direct connection between campus engagement and student commerce.

The gigs/opportunities layer allows approved societies, student organisations, campus stakeholders and verified businesses to publish legitimate paid needs such as photography, graphic design, catering, tutoring, web work or event support. Multiple verified sellers could respond with proposals/quotes.

Critical institutional boundary

The platform must not be framed as a way to bypass Eduvos procurement. Stakeholder interviews should explicitly ask which opportunities may be awarded to students through the marketplace and which must follow formal procurement or contracting procedures.

Why events matter strategically

Events can seed marketplace liquidity. A campus market day, workshop or entrepreneurship event can create concentrated buyer/seller activity, generate verified transactions, expose new sellers and create measurable engagement for the Incubation Hub.

31. Social discovery: campus-first reels, follows and recommendations

The user wants a TikTok-style short-video discovery feed, but the research goal should be commerce discovery rather than recreating a generic social network. Sellers can post product/service reels; organisers can post events/opportunities; buyers can post transaction-linked reviews, recommendations and campus content. The feed defaults to the student's campus and expands across Eduvos.

Benefits to test

- Show products/services in a richer format than static listings.
- Give new sellers organic discovery opportunities.
- Promote events, gigs and campus activity.
- Create social proof through transaction-linked reviews.

Risks

- Popularity may overwhelm relevance and trust.
- High moderation volume for user-generated video.
- Attention-maximising ranking can conflict with student wellbeing and marketplace purpose.
- Commercial and non-commercial campus content can become confusing.

A safer research direction is a purposeful discovery feed: ranking uses campus, relevance, availability, trust and freshness, with controls to prevent a few high-engagement sellers from monopolising exposure. Paid boosts remain out of scope.

32. Group buying, rewards and campus recognition

Group purchases can make sense where demand is naturally pooled: catering, printing, merchandise, event supplies or transport-like services. A group order should define minimum participants, deadline, price rule, cancellation conditions and what happens if the threshold is not reached.

The user is open to a points system but wants Eduvos to help define rewards. That is the correct governance model. Points could recognise completed purchases, reliable selling, event participation, referrals, courier reliability, verified reviews and Incubation workshop participation. They should not become an unregulated cash substitute.

Two reward layers

- Eduvos-wide: consistent recognition and institution-level programmes.
- Campus-local: challenges, event participation, seller discovery and campus-specific partnerships.

Leaderboards

Campus recognition can include Trusted Sellers, highly rated services, reliable couriers, fast-growing businesses and constructive community contributors. Rankings should be category-specific, time-bounded and resistant to pure sales-volume domination. Some internal rankings may be better kept private to avoid unhealthy competition or gaming.

33. Incubation Hub intelligence: from dashboard to intervention

The user wants the Incubation Hub to actively use marketplace evidence. Marketplace performance can automatically make a seller eligible for support; direct contact requires the seller to have opted in. If not opted in, relevant support opportunities can still appear inside the seller dashboard.

Internal Business Health Score

The user wants the raw Business Health Score visible to Incubation Hub staff, not to sellers. It can combine interpretable indicators such as sales trend, repeat customers, fulfilment, cancellations, disputes, ratings, response time, demand signals and account activity. The score must show its components and limitations rather than present a mysterious AI judgement.

Seller-facing guidance

Instead of exposing the internal score, AI can notify the seller with concrete observations: response time is slipping, cancellations are rising, a frequently requested product is missing, or a particular category is gaining demand. These prompts should be factual and explainable.

AI-assisted intervention

AI can recommend interventions to Hub staff - marketing support, pricing review, formalisation guidance, funding readiness, stock/operations coaching or mentorship. Staff approve the intervention. Then the AI can generate the user-selected 30-day improvement plan with daily/weekly actions, measurable goals, checkpoints and progress tracking. The plan should remain editable by staff and student.

34. AI as a visible compliance and marketplace assistant

AI is not intended as a novelty chatbot. The proposed role is operational: make the marketplace safer, easier to list on and more intelligent. NIST AI RMF provides a useful governance lens: map the context, measure risk, manage controls and govern the system, with transparency and human oversight. South Africa's emerging AI policy direction likewise emphasises responsible, inclusive, human-centred governance. [R31] [R32]

High-value AI use cases

- Listing completeness and policy checks before publication.
- Prohibited-category detection and moderation triage.
- Ingredient/allergen completeness checks for food.
- Duplicate/scam-pattern detection and suspicious transaction flags.
- Natural-language search mapped into filters.
- Demand clustering and opportunity summaries.
- Seller analytics summaries and factual coaching prompts.
- Incubation intervention recommendations and approved 30-day plans.

Human-control rules

AI may block or hold a specific listing where the policy match is clear, but account punishment, disputes and high-impact decisions require a human-review path. AI outputs should carry reasons and confidence; moderation decisions should be logged and appealable.

35. Privacy and POPIA: the platform should know less than it can

The platform will handle identity, payments, messages, location context, transaction history, reviews and potentially sensitive dispute evidence. POPIA therefore needs to influence data architecture, not only the privacy policy. [R24]

Data-minimisation principles

- Public profiles never display raw student numbers or government ID details.
- Identity verification records are separated from public marketplace profiles.
- Analytics use pseudonymous user IDs wherever possible.
- Precise location is optional and task-specific; campus is the default location context.
- Courier live-location history should not be retained longer than operationally necessary.
- Dispute evidence has access controls and retention rules.
- Internal Business Health Scores are restricted to authorised Incubation staff.

Automated decision risk

Where AI or scoring materially affects access, suspension, opportunity eligibility or other significant outcomes, EduHackers should avoid opaque automated decisions. Explainability, human review and appeal are safer both ethically and under data-protection principles.

The architecture should maintain a clear record of purpose, lawful basis, retention, access roles and deletion for each data class. Privacy should be part of the ERD and event taxonomy, not a final checklist.

36. Security architecture: marketplace trust depends on object-level controls

The platform combines user-generated content, messaging, payments, uploads, disputes and multiple roles. OWASP ASVS 5.0 is an appropriate baseline for security requirements. [R34]

Priority controls for the MVP

- Strong authentication/session management and secure reset/recovery.
- Server-side role and object-level authorisation on every sensitive action.
- Ownership checks for listings, orders, messages, disputes and evidence files.
- Server-side input validation and parameterised database access.
- XSS and CSRF protections where applicable.
- Safe image/file upload processing and malware/content checks.
- Rate limits for login, messaging, listing, review and dispute endpoints.
- Secret management outside source code.
- Admin/moderator audit logs.
- Abuse reporting, blocking and moderation queues.

Threat-model focus

The highest-value abuse paths include account takeover, fake sellers, fraudulent disputes, listing manipulation, payout diversion, courier impersonation, evidence tampering and insecure file uploads. Security testing should trace these user journeys rather than only scan endpoints generically.

37. Accessibility and inclusive interaction

The brief explicitly values accessibility/ease of use. WCAG 2.2 provides the core standard, organised around perceivable, operable, understandable and robust experiences. [R35]

MVP accessibility requirements

- High enough contrast and readable typography in light/dark themes.
- Keyboard access and visible focus states.
- Meaningful labels, error messages and status announcements.
- Reflow on small screens without horizontal page scrolling.
- Touch targets large enough for mobile use.
- No important status communicated only by colour.
- Captions/transcripts or text alternatives for marketplace reels where practical.
- Accessible forms for seller onboarding, checkout, disputes and booking.

A dark interface is not automatically accessible. Contrast, focus, motion and text size still require testing. The product should also perform acceptably on ordinary student connections; a highly animated feed should not make core commerce unusable on constrained bandwidth.

38. Reference architecture and data boundaries

A modular architecture helps separate the parts that are likely to change. Payment providers may change, AI models may change, campuses may add local rules, and the marketplace may phase features. These concerns should not be tightly coupled to the core order model.

Reference architecture - modular enough to scale across campuses



Figure 13. Reference architecture for research and prototyping; technology choices remain open.

Core bounded areas

- Identity and roles.
- Marketplace catalogue and availability.
- Orders/bookings/rentals/events.
- Payments/payout orchestration.
- Delivery and pickup.
- Trust, reviews, disputes and enforcement.
- Social/reels and notifications.
- Analytics/demand intelligence.
- Incubation records/interventions.

For the Hack Jam prototype, these can live in a modular monolith rather than premature microservices. The important thing is clean domain boundaries, event instrumentation and replaceable integrations.

39. Conceptual data model

User	Authentication identity; links to StudentProfile and roles
StudentProfile	Campus/study context and public-safe identity
SellerProfile	Seller standing, trust tier, verification state
Business	Optional brand/storefront linked to seller after trust unlock
Listing	Shared product/service/rental/digital/food metadata + subtype
Availability	Stock, pickup windows, service slots or rental calendar
SearchEvent	Search intent, campus, filters, result state; pseudonymous analytics
Request	Wanted/custom need when supply is absent or custom
OpportunitySignal	Aggregated unmet demand or stakeholder opportunity
Order / Booking	Commercial state machine for product/service
PaymentHold	PSP reference, amount, release/refund/dispute state
DeliveryTask	Courier/pickup/transfer fulfilment and evidence
Rental	Deposit, condition evidence, return deadline, late charges
Event / Ticket	Capacity, RSVP, ticket, waitlist, vendor application
Review	Transaction-verified buyer/seller feedback
Dispute / EvidenceFile	Human-reviewed claim and supporting evidence
Report / EnforcementAction	Policy moderation, probation/suspension and appeal
IncubationRecord	Eligibility, opt-in, staff observations, interventions
AIRecommendation	Reasoned suggestion, confidence, reviewer/approval state
AuditLog	Security/admin/moderation trace

Critical relationship

SearchEvent → UnmetDemand → OpportunitySignal is the core differentiation. The model should preserve enough context to aggregate useful demand without retaining unnecessary individual-level behaviour.

40. Analytics and marketplace-health metrics

Raw registrations are weak marketplace metrics. The important question is whether supply and demand successfully meet. The team should instrument the prototype early so research sessions generate behavioural evidence.

Core events

search_performed; search_result_opened; search_zero_result; listing_viewed; seller_viewed; seller_contacted; request_created; request_matched; opportunity_viewed; opportunity_applied; idea_test_created; order_started; order_accepted; order_completed; order_cancelled; review_created; dispute_opened; report_created; delivery_started; delivery_completed; event_rsvp; ticket_purchased; rental_started; rental_returned; mentor_intervention_created.

Core metrics

- Search success rate and local-campus search success.
- Zero-result rate before and after fallback.
- Request fill rate and time to first response.
- Listing-view → enquiry/order conversion.
- Order completion and cancellation.
- Repeat buyer and repeat seller activity.
- Seller activation and Trusted Seller progression.
- Campus/category liquidity.
- Dispute/report rate.
- Opportunity conversion: unmet demand → new offer → completed transaction.

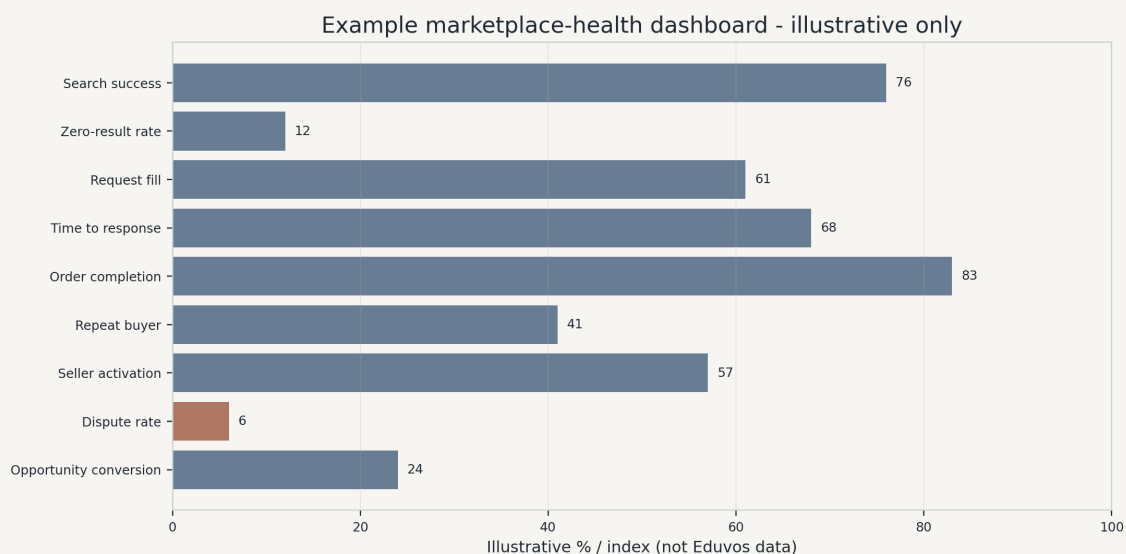


Figure 14. Illustrative dashboard only - values are placeholders, not Eduvos results.

41. Payment architecture and compliance research

Payment protection is both a UX feature and a regulated money-movement problem. Paystack documents transaction splits and subaccounts specifically for marketplace-like scenarios. PASA documents TPPP obligations for accepting or disbursing payments on behalf of multiple parties. [R20] [R23]

Architecture principle

EduHackers should model an internal PaymentHold state without assuming Eduvos literally holds money. The external PSP/payment partner remains the system of record for authorisation, settlement, refunds and payout. The marketplace stores references and business state.

Payment research checklist

- Which PSP supports seller subaccounts / marketplace onboarding in South Africa?
- Can funds be protected until buyer confirmation under the provider's terms?
- How are refunds and partial refunds represented?
- Who bears transaction fees?
- How quickly can seller payouts occur?

- What KYC is required from sellers beyond Eduvos/ID verification?
- How are chargebacks and bank disputes allocated?
- What PASA/sponsoring-bank requirements apply to the final model?
- How should crypto be treated if enabled in a later phase?

42. Consumer, electronic-transaction and platform-policy implications

South African consumer and electronic-transaction law affect marketplace disclosures, transaction terms, refunds and supplier information. The Hack Jam team should not attempt to become legal counsel, but the product concept should expose the issues clearly and avoid promising policies that contradict law. [R25] [R26]

Policy areas requiring institutional/legal sign-off

- Who is the contractual seller: student, Eduvos, or both in different contexts?
- How prominently must seller identity/contact information be disclosed?
- Cancellation/cooling-off rights for different transaction types.
- Return/refund exclusions for custom services, digital goods and perishables.
- Event ticket cancellation and organiser obligations.
- Rental deposits, late fees and damage deductions.
- Student courier liability and insurance.
- Food seller eligibility and campus health/safety requirements.
- Dispute appeal and record retention.

The safest product design makes terms contextual. A buyer renting a camera should see rental/deposit/late rules; a buyer booking design work should see the service brief, 30% deposit and cancellation rules; a food order should show ingredients, allergens and fulfilment timing.

43. Research hypotheses to test across campuses

H1	Student-business discovery is inefficient	Last real purchase / search journey interviews
H2	Discovery depends heavily on fragmented informal channels	Buyer + seller channel mapping
H3	Customer acquisition is a major seller constraint	"Last five customers" interviews
H4	Eduvos + ID verification increases trust	Prototype comparison
H5	Meaningful unmet demand exists by campus/category	Interviews + survey + zero-result prototype telemetry
H6	Some students want income but do not know what to start	Aspiring-entrepreneur interviews
H7	Demand evidence helps students choose what to test	Opportunity Engine concept test
H8	Incubation staff can act on marketplace evidence	Staff dashboard/intervention test
H9	Availability/proximity matter more for physical than digital offers	Search/booking prototype test
H10	Transaction history is more trusted than generic star ratings	Reputation prototype comparison
H11	Campus organisations generate legitimate student-supplier opportunities	Society/stakeholder interviews
H12	Cross-campus fallback recovers otherwise lost demand	Prototype task completion
H13	Protected payment increases transaction confidence	Checkout/payment concept test
H14	Campus-first reels improve discovery without overwhelming search	Usability/attention test
H15	Trusted Seller progression motivates quality without blocking new sellers	Seller interviews + ranking prototype

44. Interview programme: observe behaviour before pitching the solution

The first round should be qualitative and behavioural. A practical target is 23-38 interactions across buyers, active sellers, aspiring sellers, Incubation/staff and societies/organisers. This is not statistically representative; the purpose is to uncover patterns, language, constraints and failure modes.

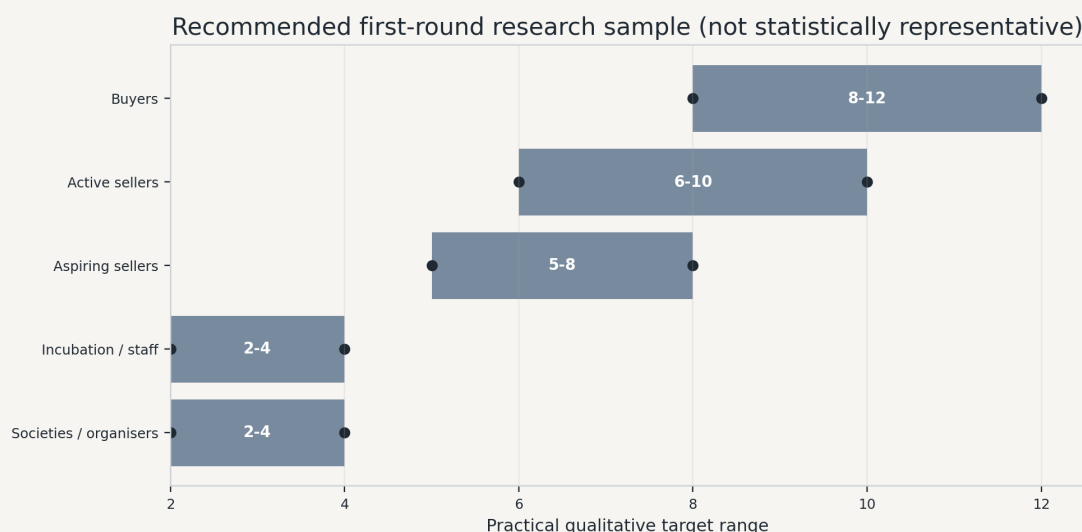


Figure 15. Recommended practical first-round qualitative target ranges.

Buyer prompts

- Tell me about the last thing you bought from another student. How did you find them?
- What was the last product/service you could not find? What did you do next?
- What information made you trust or distrust the seller?
- How did payment, collection/delivery and follow-up work?

Seller prompts

- Walk me through your last five customers. Where did each come from?
- What takes the most time besides producing the product/service?
- Which requests do customers make that you cannot fulfil?
- How do you manage availability around classes?

Aspiring seller prompts

- If you wanted to earn from your skills this month, what would stop you?
- How would you decide what to sell? What proof would reduce the risk?

Incubation / stakeholder prompts

- How do you currently know which ventures need support?
- What marketplace evidence would be useful, misleading or inappropriate?
- Which campus opportunities can students legitimately fulfil and which require formal procurement?

45. Survey design: measure patterns after interviews reveal them

The survey should not lead with “Would you use our app?” because stated intent is weak evidence. It should quantify behaviours that interviews uncover.

Core survey fields

- Campus / study mode.
- Bought from another student in last six months? What category?
- Discovery channel used.
- Difficulty finding a suitable seller (scale).
- Trust factors selected.
- Recent unsuccessful search / unmet need.
- Seller status and customer-acquisition channels.
- Largest business constraint.
- Frequency of unfulfillable requests.
- Interest in earning from skills and barriers to starting.
- Perceived usefulness of Eduvos verification, live availability, protected payment and demand trends.

Survey outputs should be segmented by campus and user role. Small campus sample sizes should be clearly labelled; never convert a convenience sample into institution-wide percentages.

46. Prototype tests: convert the concept into falsifiable tasks

Discovery fallback	Find an unavailable product/service and continue	Task completion, fallback used, confusion, abandonment
Protected payment	Buy an item and explain when seller gets paid	Comprehension, trust, fee clarity
Service booking	Book a service with live availability and 30% deposit	Booking success, deposit understanding
Trust	Choose between new seller and Trusted Seller profiles	Trust factors, fairness concerns
Wanted request	Post a need after zero result	Completion, privacy concerns, expected responses
Demand Intelligence	Aspiring seller reviews opportunity signal	Would-act evidence; information needed
Incubation dashboard	Staff interpret health indicators and AI recommendation	Correct interpretation, actionability, concerns
Reels discovery	Find a relevant product through campus feed	Relevance, distraction, seller fairness
Dispute	Open a claim and submit evidence	Understanding, evidence burden, fairness
Rental	Rent high-value item with condition/deposit flow	Risk comprehension, deposit acceptance

Every test should end with a research note: what happened, why it happened, whether the underlying hypothesis gained/ lost support, and what requirement changes. “Users liked it” is not sufficient.

47. MVP cutline: prove the system before building the super-app

Verified Eduvos identity concept	Aspiring-entrepreneur pathway	Full live multi-PSP money movement
Personal seller + listing	Opportunity board / quote marketplace	Advanced crypto payments
Products + services	Student courier pilot	Full reels creator ecosystem
Campus-first search + availability	Event RSVP/ticket prototype	Large-scale subscriptions
Cross-campus fallback concept	Rental flow prototype	Advanced fraud automation
Protected-payment state model	Trusted Seller unlock	Institution-wide loyalty economy
Buyer/seller messaging	Incubation health dashboard	Procurement integration
Request / zero-result capture	AI compliance assistant	Advanced AI recommender
Completion-linked review	Designated pickup proof	Multi-campus logistics optimisation
Report/dispute prototype	Seller 30-day intervention plan	Monetisation optimisation
Demand Intelligence loop	Accessibility/performance testing	Production-scale operations

The MVP recommendation is not a final build order; Week 2 research can move items. The non-negotiable demonstration should be the closed loop: demand is captured, the marketplace attempts to fulfil it, failure becomes structured opportunity evidence, and the Incubation layer can respond.

48. Eight-week research-to-build roadmap

Hack Jam 8-week delivery rhythm - research should drive build decisions



Figure 16. Hack Jam journey aligned to the official eight-week cadence.

Week 2 - research

Interviews, survey, competitor evidence, assumptions, payment/compliance spikes, research repository and first synthesis.

Week 3 - concept / requirements

JTBD, problem statements, prioritised hypotheses, concept tests, initial architecture, ERD, RBAC and event model.

Week 4 - design

Buyer, seller, aspiring entrepreneur and Incubation flows; accessibility checks; protected-payment and fallback prototypes.

Week 5 - MVP

Build P0 flows, instrument telemetry, enforce object-level permissions, create test data and integration stubs for payment/notifications.

Week 6 - user testing

Usability tests, failure-state tests, security checks, performance/accessibility checks, evidence synthesis.

Week 7 - refine / pitch

Fix high-impact issues, harden demo, create before/after evidence, finalise implementation risks and pitch narrative.

Week 8 - Demo Day

Demonstrate problem evidence → closed-loop solution → tested prototype → practical architecture → realistic next steps.

49. Risk matrix and mitigation priorities



Figure 17. Relative research risk matrix. Placement is qualitative and should be updated as evidence arrives.

Held funds / payments	High regulatory and trust impact	Use regulated PSP; PASA/legal review; prototype states before live funds
Cold start / liquidity	Empty marketplace destroys value	Seed campus/category wedges; capture requests; events as launch moments
Scope overload	Broad vision can miss MVP	P0/P1/Later cutline; research gates
AI moderation error	False blocks harm students	Confidence thresholds; human review; appeals
Food safety	Physical health and institutional liability	Category controls; compliance review; seller requirements
Privacy/location	Students are identifiable in a closed community	Minimise precise location; pseudonymise analytics; role-based access
Courier safety	Physical handoff and travel risk	Approved zones; clear eligibility; limited location retention
Academic misuse	Platform could enable misconduct	Clear policy; category rules; moderation
Cross-campus cost	Fallback may be economically impractical	Compare delivery/transfer costs and user willingness

50. Strategic focus: what EduHackers should optimise for

The concept should not optimise for the largest feature list. It should optimise for five linked outcomes.

1. Liquidity

A buyer should find a usable option quickly. Search success, fallback success, response time and request fill matter more than registration counts.

2. Trust

Verification, protected payments, transaction-linked reputation, disputes and designated handoffs should reduce uncertainty without creating impossible onboarding.

3. Opportunity creation

Unmet demand should become structured information that can create new offers and new student ventures.

4. Business growth

Trusted sellers should gain better tools and opportunities through earned standing, while new sellers retain discovery access.

5. Institutional learning

The Incubation Hub should gain privacy-conscious evidence that helps it target real support, without turning the marketplace into a surveillance or opaque scoring system.

One-sentence position

EduHackers proposes a campus-first, all-Eduvos marketplace that protects transactions, prevents dead-end demand, helps students discover what to sell, and gives the Incubation Hub evidence to grow real student businesses.

51. Recommended pitch claims - and claims to avoid

"Existing campus marketplaces already solve verification, listings, chat, payments and requests."	"Nobody has ever built a student marketplace like this."
"Our white-space hypothesis is the closed demand → venture → incubation feedback loop."	"Demand Intelligence is definitely what Eduvos students want."
"We propose 2% platform commission; processor-fee treatment still needs validation."	"Every transaction only costs 2%."
"Any verified student could eventually sell, subject to ID/trust rules."	"This is already Eduvos policy."
"AI assists compliance and recommendations with human review for high-impact decisions."	"AI automatically decides who is trustworthy."
"The MVP proves the loop; broader modes are phased research."	"We will build every feature in eight weeks."

Judges are likely to reward a concept that is ambitious but credible. Transparent boundaries strengthen the pitch because they show the team understands implementation risk rather than hiding it.

52. Immediate work plan for Paballo Kali - Developer / Research Lead

Research execution

- Finalise behavioural interview guides and participant recruitment across more than one campus where possible.
- Run buyer, seller, aspiring-entrepreneur, Incubation and society/stakeholder sessions.
- Maintain raw observations separate from interpretation.
- Synthesize affinity clusters and update H1-H15 status.
- Build the competitor evidence matrix and reference log.

Technical research

- Identity/verification spike: what can Eduvos provide?
- Payment/PSP spike: protected funds, subaccounts, refunds, fee bearer, payout/KYC.
- ERD v0 and RBAC matrix.
- Event taxonomy and privacy boundary.
- Threat model and ASVS control checklist.
- Performance/accessibility baseline for mobile-first web/PWA.

Decision outputs by the end of research week

- Validated pains and rejected assumptions.
- P0/P1/Later scope.
- Evidence for or against Demand Intelligence as the lead differentiation.
- Technical blockers and institutional questions.
- Research readout that Product, UX/UI, Business Analysis and Pitch can directly use.

53. Research repository structure and traceability

Use anonymous participant IDs such as BUY-01, SEL-04, ASP-03, INC-01 and SOC-02. Do not place student numbers in the research repository.

Observation record

Participant: SEL-04

Context: last customer-acquisition journey

Raw observation: record what actually happened, not interpretation

Tag: DISCOVERY / TRUST / PAYMENT / AVAILABILITY / etc.

Interpretation: separate researcher inference

Hypothesis affected: H3

Requirement implication: if evidence repeats

Source link / consent: where applicable

Recommended tags

DISCOVERY • TRUST • PRICE • PAYMENT • COMMUNICATION • AVAILABILITY • DELIVERY • CUSTOMER_ACQUISITION • MARKETING • UNMET_DEMAND • MENTORING • STARTUP_IDEA • SAFETY • ACCESSIBILITY • FULFILMENT • REPEAT_PURCHASE

Traceability example

R-012 → INS-004 → H5 → REQ-007 → FIGMA-FLOW-03 → GH-ISSUE-18 → TEST-003 → EVIDENCE-09

This chain makes the final presentation defensible: when a judge asks why a feature exists, the team can show the evidence path.

54. Open decisions that research must not hide

Exact payment partner	Fees, held-fund support, KYC and payout differ	Provider/legal conversations + technical spike
Who bears PSP fees	2% commission may not cover cards	Unit economics + student price sensitivity
Exact Trusted Seller thresholds	R1k + 10 sales is recommendation, not validated	Seller interviews + pilot data
Food seller approval model	Institutional health/safety obligations	Eduvos legal/operations/health input
Courier insurance/liability	Physical-delivery risk	Eduvos operations + insurer/legal input
Brand storefront benefits	Could create unfair advantage	Seller/buyer research + ranking test
Business Health Score weights	Can become misleading/opaque	Incubation staff co-design + pilot
Reels ranking	Can bias exposure and attention	Usability/fairness test
Subscription categories	Recurring billing risk	Demand + legal/payment validation
Cross-campus logistics	Cost and timing may overwhelm value	Pilot route/campus analysis

Decision principle

Do not “solve” institutional unknowns with assumptions. Put them in the risk/decision log, identify the owner who can answer them, and build the prototype so the decision can change without rewriting the entire system.

55. Conclusion

The market research changes the question from “How do we build a student marketplace?” to “What does Eduvos uniquely gain from owning the marketplace loop?” The answer is not simply listings. Existing platforms already show verification, secure payments, wanted boards, booking, analytics, campus delivery and entrepreneurship support.

The stronger EduHackers concept treats commerce as evidence. Every search, fallback, request, transaction, repeat purchase, cancellation and opportunity can help the marketplace become more useful. Repeated unmet demand can reveal what students want. A student can test an offer against that demand. A seller can earn trust and graduate into a stronger storefront. The Incubation Hub can receive privacy-conscious evidence and approved AI recommendations, then support the student through a human-governed intervention and 30-day plan.

That vision is ambitious. The right Hack Jam strategy is therefore to prove the loop, not build the whole universe. The research should establish the real Eduvos problems first; the MVP should demonstrate trust, discovery, protected transaction state, unmet-demand capture and incubation intelligence; and the broader modes should be staged based on evidence.

“A marketplace that does not stop at matching buyers and sellers - it helps Euvos discover, validate and grow the next student business.”

56. References

References are grouped as a working research bibliography. URLs are clickable in this PDF. Market features and pricing should be re-verified immediately before implementation.

- R1. Eduvos Hack Jam 2026 Brief - Incubation Hub Marketplace
Uploaded project brief; challenge, roles, journey, AI-use requirements, judging criteria and IP terms.
Local source supplied by Eduvos.
- R2. Eduvos Annual Report 2025
Student footprint by campus; Incubation Hub pilot; societies and campus engagement.
<https://www.eduvos.com/eduvos-annual-report.pdf>
- R3. Eduvos: Students Connect with Industry at Career Fairs (2026)
12 campuses; 1,700+ students; 240+ employers.
<https://www.eduvos.com/eduvosblog/eduvos-students-connect-with-industry-at-career-fairs/>
- R4. UWC - From Fridge Hunt to Campus Marketplace
Student verification, product/service discovery, search optimisation and security testing.
<https://www.uwc.ac.za/news-and-announcements/news/from-fridge-hunt-to-campus-marketplace>
- R5. Makethe - Student Seller Marketplace
University verification, seller stores, products/services, bookings, payments, analytics and CRM.
<https://makethe.co.za/Sell>
- R6. Campus Needs - How It Works / About
Verified students, protected payments, campus handoffs and campus-only focus.
<https://campusneeds.me/how-it-works>
- R7. KANU
Entrepreneurship learning, school marketplace, verified outcomes and venture activity.
<https://kanu.us/>
- R8. Campus Marketplace - App Store
Verified campus users, Paystack payments, messaging, search and favourites.
<https://apps.apple.com/za/app/campus-marketplace/id6755789641>
- R9. UniBay - App Store
South African student marketplace with listings, chat and study-note functionality.
<https://apps.apple.com/za/app/unibay/id6759392376>
- R10. Student Hub Marketing - App Store
Campus buying/selling, real-time chat, campus authentication and notifications.
<https://apps.apple.com/za/app/student-hub-marketing/id6761091315>
- R11. Grid: Campus Marketplace - Google Play
Wanted Board for buyer requests and seller responses.
<https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.galvam.grid>
- R12. CampuzBhiz - App Store
Campus products/services, food delivery, live rider tracking, tickets, vendor dashboard and rider system.
<https://apps.apple.com/za/app/campuzbhiz/id6761507551>
- R13. Yaga South Africa - Payment / Buyer / Seller Protection
Held payment, buyer confirmation, returns/refunds and platform-protected transactions.
<https://support.yaga.co.za/hc/en-us/articles/22458022801821-Payment-Protection>
- R14. Bob Shop - Buyer Protection Programme
Tiered buyer protection, in-platform payments and seller reputation.
https://www.bobshop.co.za/content/23/Buyer_Protection_Programme.html
- R15. Bob Shop - Verified User / Ratings
Identity verification, eligibility for store status, and two-sided ratings.
<https://help.bobshop.co.za/portal/en/kb/articles/become-a-verified-user>
- R16. Mr D - delivery / payment experience
South African reference for location-aware fulfilment, order status and electronic payments.
<https://www.mrd.com/>
- R17. World Wide Worx / Mastercard - Online Retail in South Africa 2026
R159bn forecast, 22.5% growth and 10% of national retail turnover.
<https://www.worldwideworx.com/onlineretailsa2026/>
- R18. Peach Payments - Online Retail in South Africa 2026
Smartphone/browser behaviour, payment-method shifts, digital wallet and pay-by-bank trends.
<https://www.peachpayments.com/2026-online-retail-report/>
- R19. Paystack South Africa Pricing
Current local card and EFT pricing.

<https://paystack.com/za/pricing>

R20. Paystack Transaction Splits

Subaccounts and marketplace split-payment functionality.

<https://support.paystack.com/en/articles/2132802>

R21. Payfast Fees

Current card and Instant EFT fees.

<https://payfast.io/fees/>

R22. Ozow Pricing

Pay-by-bank, PayShap, payouts, refunds and crypto pricing.

<https://ozow.com/pricing>

R23. Payments Association of South Africa - TPPP Registration

Registration obligations when accepting/dispersing payments for multiple parties.

<https://authorisation.pasa.org.za/so-and-tppp/tppp-registration/>

R24. Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA)

South African data protection and automated-decision considerations.

<https://www.gov.za/documents/protection-personal-information-act>

R25. Electronic Communications and Transactions Act 25 of 2002

Electronic transaction and consumer disclosure framework.

<https://www.gov.za/documents/electronic-communications-and-transactions-act>

R26. Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008

Fair marketplace practices, consumer rights and supplier obligations.

<https://www.gov.za/documents/consumer-protection-act>

R27. Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises, R638 (2018)

Food-premises hygiene and Certificate of Acceptability context.

<https://www.gov.za/documents/foodstuffs-cosmetics-and-disinfectants-act-regulations-general-hygiene-requirements-food>

R28. Food Labelling Regulations R146

Ingredient, allergen and labelling requirements relevant to food listings.

<https://www.health.gov.za/>

R29. SARS - Sole Proprietorship

A sole proprietor may trade under a fictitious/trade name but remains the natural person.

<https://www.sars.gov.za/businesses-and-employers/small-businesses-taxpayers/starting-a-business-and-tax/sole-proprietorship/>

R30. SARS - Turnover Tax (2026)

R2.3m annual turnover limit and 2026/27 threshold changes for qualifying micro businesses.

<https://www.sars.gov.za/types-of-tax/turnover-tax/>

R31. NIST AI Risk Management Framework + GenAI Profile

AI trustworthiness, governance, measurement and human oversight.

<https://www.nist.gov/itl/ai-risk-management-framework>

R32. South Africa Draft National AI Policy (2026)

Responsible governance, ethical/inclusive AI and human-centred deployment direction.

<https://www.gov.za/>

R33. South Africa National Entrepreneurship Strategy (2026)

Policy emphasis on skills, technology, finance, markets and entrepreneurship ecosystem support.

<https://www.gov.za/>

R34. OWASP ASVS 5.0

Application-security verification requirements and control baseline.

<https://owasp.org/www-project-application-security-verification-standard/>

R35. W3C WCAG 2.2

Accessibility standard for perceivable, operable, understandable and robust experiences.

<https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/>

R36. Fihla & Gavaza (2026) - Studentpreneurship at a South African University

Qualitative evidence that support mechanisms can be uneven, fragmented and inconsistently accessible.

<https://www.mdpi.com/2076-3387/16/6/258>

R37. Student Entrepreneurship Support at South African Public Universities (2024)

Mentorship, training, networking, business advice and institutional support themes.

<https://scielo.org.za/>

R38. Transition Experiences from Student to Business Owner (2024)

South African evidence on resourcing/capability challenges and reliance on informal support networks.

<https://scielo.org.za/>

R39. Council on Higher Education - Academic Integrity / GenAI guidance

Higher-education academic-integrity context relevant to tutoring and student-created academic resources.

<https://www.che.ac.za/>

Appendix A. Role-permission matrix

Buy/book/rent	✓	✓	✓	✓	—	—
Create standard listings	—	✓	✓	—	—	—
Brand storefront	—	—	✓	—	—	—
Selected subscriptions	—	—	✓	—	—	—
Accept delivery task	—	—	optional	✓	—	—
See Business Health Score	—	—	—	—	✓	limited
Approve intervention	—	—	—	—	✓	—
Review dispute	—	—	—	—	—	✓
Apply probation/suspension	—	—	—	—	—	✓
Appeal own action	✓	✓	✓	✓	—	—

Appendix B. Analytics event dictionary

search_performed	timestamp, pseudonymous_user_id, campus, query/category, filters
search_zero_result	same + fallback stage
request_created	request_id, campus, category, desired timing/budget where supplied
request_matched	request_id, seller/listing match, time-to-match
listing_viewed	listing_id, campus context, source surface
seller_contacted	seller_id, listing/request source
order_started / completed / cancelled	order_id, mode, campus, timestamps, reason code
payment_protected / released / refunded	PSP reference only; never raw card/bank secrets
delivery_started / completed	task id, method, pickup zone, timestamps
review_created	transaction id, reviewer role, rating dimensions
dispute_opened / resolved	reason, evidence count, resolution code
opportunity_signal_created	aggregated category/campus, minimum-count threshold
idea_test_created	opportunity source, experiment type
event_rsvp / ticket_purchased	event id, campus, capacity state
rental_started / returned / late	rental id, condition evidence refs, timestamps
mentor_intervention_created	seller/business id, staff approver, intervention type

Appendix C. Interview note template

Participant ID: _____ Segment: Buyer / Seller / Aspiring / Staff / Society

Campus: _____ Date: _____ Consent: Notes / Recording (where permitted)

Behavioural episode

What happened? Who was involved? What channel was used? What did the participant do next? What evidence can be observed?

Raw observations

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Tags / interpretation

Tags: _____ Pattern candidate: _____

Hypothesis affected: _____ Supporting / contradicting / unclear

Possible requirement implication: _____

Researcher caution

Do not convert one memorable quote into a general finding. Keep direct observation separate from interpretation and wait for repeated evidence.

Appendix D. AI-use transparency log for Hack Jam work

Desk research synthesis	Drafted summaries / comparison structure	Check every factual claim and current pricing	Reference IDs / URLs	Team edits wording and scope
Interview guide	Question drafting	Research Lead checks for leading questions	Research method rationale	Pilot then revise
Architecture	Option generation	Developer validates feasibility/security	ASVS / provider docs	Architecture decision record
UI copy	Draft labels / states	UX/UI tests comprehension	Usability evidence	Figma revision
Code	Scaffolding/tests where used	Developer reviews, tests, sec checks	Git history / CI	Refactor before merge
Pitch	Structure and wording support	Pitch Lead verifies all claims	Evidence tracker	Team rehearses/adapts

This appendix supports the brief requirement that AI contributions be transparent, verified and used as support rather than a replacement for student decision-making. [R1]